Elections

One line: How India runs the world's largest democratic exercise — electoral systems that convert votes into seats, the laws & institutions (ECI, Delimitation Commission) that keep elections free & fair, and the role of political parties.

⚡ 5-Minute Revision | 💡 Hinglish | ⚖️ FPTP vs PR | 🔥 Must-Remember Facts | 📝 Answer Guide

1 Chapter at a Glance

- **Election** = process through which we exercise the right to vote & fulfil our responsibility as citizens; regular, periodic elections lie at the core of democracy 🔥
- **Big questions:** Why are elections essential? How do electoral systems shape representation & fairness? What roles do institutions & laws play? What challenges remain?
- **Why elections matter (ARLE) 🔥: A**ccountability • **R**epresentation • **L**egitimacy • **E**quality — the vote = principal means of exercising this right

2 Key Terms — one-line meanings

Direct elections — citizens vote directly (Lok Sabha, Vidhan Sabha, local bodies)
Psephology — scientific study of elections; Greek *psēphos* = "pebble" 📌
Electoral system — method of converting votes into seats
Majority system — two rounds; winner needs >50%
STV — voters mark preferences; votes of eliminated candidates transferred
Vidhan Parishad — Legislative Council (Upper House in bicameral states)
Electoral roll — voters' list per constituency, polling-station-wise
Defection — leaving the party whose ticket you won on
RUPP — Registered Unrecognised Political Parties
VVPAT — printed slip so voters can verify their vote
MCC — Model Code of Conduct; violations via cVIGIL

Indirect elections — representatives choose leaders (President, VP, Rajya Sabha)
Constituency — territorial area electing one representative
FPTP — candidate with MOST votes wins, even if <50%
Proportional Representation — seats in proportion to votes received
Quota — minimum votes to win = valid votes ÷ seats to be filled
Delimitation — fixing number of seats & constituency boundaries
SIR — Special Intensive Revision of rolls (add/delete/verify)
Whip — party's voting instruction; defying it can disqualify
Coalition — alliance government (first national: Janata Party, 1977)
ETPBS — service voters cast postal ballots electronically

3 The Electoral System — FPTP vs Majority vs PR 🔥

- First step of conducting elections = deciding **how votes convert into seats**; the Constitution's framers chose the **plurality (FPTP)** system
- **FPTP used for:** Lok Sabha + Vidhan Sabha | **PR (via STV) used for:** Rajya Sabha, President, Vice President (+ Vidhan Parishad) 📌

Feature	FPTP (plurality)	Majority (2 rounds)	Proportional Representation
How it works	One vote per candidate in constituency; MOST votes wins (even <50%)	Needs >50%; else top two re-compete in Round 2	Vote for a party, not a person; seats ∝ votes
Textbook example 📌	**Haritbhumi:** A 40%, B 35%, C 25% → A forms govt with only 40%	**Ratnadeep:** nobody crossed 50% in Round 1 → Round 2: Y wins with 55%	**Swarnalok** (100 seats): M 40, N 35, O 15, P 10 seats — power shared by vote share
Who forms govt	Most seats (may be <50% of votes)	Round-2 majority winner	Coalitions — power shared proportionately

QUOTA	**Quota = total valid votes ÷ seats to be filled** = minimum votes to win
STV STEP 1	Voters mark preferences (1st, 2nd, 3rd…)
STV STEP 2	First-preference votes counted; candidates reaching quota declared elected
STV STEP 3	**Lowest candidate eliminated** → their votes transferred to 2nd preference marked on those ballots
STV STEP 4	Repeat until the required number are elected (Vidhan Parishad also uses PR by STV)

- **6 bicameral states (Vidhan Parishad) 📌:** Andhra Pradesh, Bihar, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Telangana, Uttar Pradesh
- Vidhan Sabha = Lower House (directly elected, FPTP); **Vidhan Parishad** members: elected by Vidhan Sabha members & local bodies + **graduates & teachers**; Governor nominates some (art, science, social service, literature, co-operatives)

4 The Laws Governing Elections 🔥

Law	What it covers
RP Act, 1950	"Rolls & boundaries" — allocation of seats, delimitation of constituencies, preparation & revision of electoral rolls; every citizen 18+ votes without discrimination
RP Act, 1951	"Conduct & disputes" — nomination, campaigns, voting procedures, post-election disputes; electoral offences & corrupt practices
Presidential & VP Act, 1952	Rules for Presidential & Vice-Presidential elections

- **Trick:** 1950 = foundation (rolls + delimitation); 1951 = fighting (conduct + disputes)
- **Corrupt practices (RPA 1951) 📌:** ① **bribery** (gift/offer/promise to vote or withdraw) ② **communal appeal** (religion, caste, race, community, language) ③ **misuse of government personnel** (gazetted officers, judges/magistrates, armed forces, police, excise)

5 Delimitation Commission

- Boundaries NOT permanent — they change with population density; without delimitation one MP might represent 5 lakh, another 25 lakh → defeats equal representation
- **Delimitation** = determining seats & fixing boundaries for Lok Sabha & Vidhan Sabha — seats-to-population ratio as equal as possible
- **Article 82 mandates it 🔥; 4 commissions so far: 1952, 1963, 1973, 2002** (long gap 1973 → 2002)

6 Election Commission of India 🔥 (whole section)

- Constitution vests in the ECI the **"superintendence, direction, and control"** of the entire election process 📌 (exact phrase!)

- **ECI = autonomous, permanent, constitutional body; established 25 January 1950** → that date = **National Voters' Day**; conducts LS, RS, Vidhan Sabha, Vidhan Parishad, President & VP elections; **Articles 324–329** 📌
- State machinery: **Chief Electoral Officer (CEO)** (ECI-appointed civil servant); District Magistrates/SDMs/Tahsildars serve as District Election Officers, Returning Officers, Electoral Registration Officers

Function	Key points
① **Electoral roll**	Enumerators visit every household → rolls per constituency, polling-station-wise; only those on the roll can vote. **SIR** = update–verify–correct: adds new 18-year-olds, deletes dead/shifted/duplicate/untraceable; claims & objections settled before final publication
② **Schedule & dates**	When 5-year term ends OR legislature dissolved; factors: weather, agricultural cycle, school/university exams, festivals
③ **Parties & symbols**	Only ECI-registered parties can contest (independents too); ECI insists on **inner-party democracy** (periodic organisational elections); classification: national / state / RUPP; symbols to recognised parties; **quasi-judicial** body in recognition & symbol disputes
④ **Free, fair & inclusive**	If fairness fails, public confidence weakens. Inclusion: PwDs, senior citizens, transgender persons, PVTGs; **voting from home for 85+ & PwDs with 40% benchmark disability — first nationwide in 2024 General Elections**; EVMs with Braille

App / System	Purpose 📌 (any 3–4)
Suvidha	For candidates/parties — nomination forms, permissions (rallies, vehicles, loudspeakers), real-time status
Voter Helpline	Registration, transposition, verification, election news
ENCORE	Form processing, dashboards, role-based access, e-rolls
Saksham	Customised services for PwDs
cVIGIL	Report MCC violations in minutes; flying squads auto-navigate to the spot
Sugam	Web-based vehicle management for election work
ETPBS	Service voters cast postal ballots electronically from outside the constituency

- **IEVP** (International Election Visitors' Programme) = flagship international programme; MoUs with **28 Election Management Bodies + 3 international organisations (IFES, International IDEA, UN)** ⭐
- **National Voters' Day pledge:** vote fearlessly, without influence of religion, race, caste, community, language or inducement

7 Political Parties

- Voters learn about candidates, policies & vision primarily through parties; parties set the agenda (manifestos, rallies, debates via media)
- **Functions 📌:** organise public opinion, campaign on issues, offer meaningful choices, enable informed decisions, provide governance/accountability/representation — work at the grassroots; India = **multi-party system** reflecting diversity
- **Defection 🔥:** abandoning the party on whose ticket a member was elected (joining another party or acting independently) — "Aaya Ram, Gaya Ram"; seen as political opportunism (or conscience)
- **Anti-Defection Law 📌:** passed **1985, 52nd Constitutional Amendment** — leaving party voluntarily or voting against the **whip** → disqualified from the House; **Speaker/Chairman decides**; purpose = prevent defection, stabilise governments

National Party (any ONE) 📌	State Party (any ONE) 📌
① 6% valid votes in **4+ states** (LS or Assembly election) + **4 LS seats**	① 6% votes in state Assembly election + **2 Assembly seats**
② **2% of LS seats** from at least **3 states**	② 6% votes in LS election from the state + 1 LS seat
③ Recognised as State Party in **4+ states**	③ 3% of Assembly seats (or ⩾3 seats, whichever is more) ④ 1 LS seat per 25 seats allotted ⑤ 8% of valid votes polled in the state

- **RUPP:** parties without enough votes/seats, or never contested since registration
- **Coalitions ⭐:** 1967 = end of single-party era, alliances begin; **1977 Janata Party = first national coalition** (backdrop: the Emergency) 📌; since late 1990s: **NDA** (BJP-led) & **UPA** (INC-led; dissolved 2023, reconstituted as the INDIA alliance)

8 Challenges to Free & Fair Elections

- Scale: **96.8 crore voters (2024)**, thousands of stations, hundreds of parties, diverse regions
- Key challenges: **misinformation, fake news, intimidation** (+ money power); misinformation manipulates opinion → confusion, even conflict
- **ECI's remedies 📌:** RPA 1950 & 1951, **MCC**, **VVPAT**, voters' awareness campaigns + constant vigilance + active citizens

9 Case Study — Ishani's First Vote 📌 (source-based Q)

STORY (state assembly elections)

Ishani (just turned 18) **registered online** via ECI portal; went with mother & disabled brother; police-guarded station; **wheelchair + volunteers**; only **3 officials** on duty; forgot Voter ID & Aadhaar — **still allowed to vote** (other valid documents); saw her **VVPAT slip**; her **89-year-old grandmother voted from home**; wondered how police on duty vote.

Takeaways: ① online registration + PwD inclusion ② other documents can replace Voter ID ③ VVPAT verifies the vote ④ service voters (police/army) use postal ballots — **ETPBS**. **MCC violations shown:** wall writings, posters & pamphlets near election day.

Elections = "**festival of democracy**" — **no voter left behind** (station even for a single voter). Debate: "One Nation, One Election" — efficiency vs limitations.

10 💡 Hinglish Me Samjho — difficult concepts, ek line mein

Elections ka importance: democracy ki soul — Accountability (warna 5 saal baad nikal denge), Representation, Legitimacy (janta ki mandate se sarkar), Equality (PM ki vote = kiraye-daar ki vote).

FPTP vs PR: FPTP = race ka winner (sabse aage, chahe 30% hi ho — Haritbhumi); Majority = "50%+ dikhaao, nahi to top-2 dobara"; PR = pie — jitne % votes, utni % seats (Swarnalok). STV = PR + preference transfer.

Delimitation: classes ko sections mein divide karna taaki har section mein barabar students — warna ek MLA 5 lakh logon ka, doosra 25 lakh ka!
Defection "Aaya Ram Gaya Ram": party X ki ticket se jeeta, phir chupke se party Y mein — isliye 1985 mein 52nd Amendment: party chhodi ya whip ke against vote → disqualify; Speaker faisla karta hai.
Fake news ka kya karna hai: WhatsApp pe "forward karo warna vote cancel" = sab fake! ECI ka jawab: MCC + VVPAT (receipt — EVM galat to nahi?) + awareness. Tumhara jawab: verify karo, aankh band karke forward mat karo!

11 🔥 MUST REMEMBER — if nothing else, this!

- Elections = soul of democracy: **ARLE** — accountability, representation, legitimacy, equality
- **Direct:** LS, Vidhan Sabha, local bodies (every 5 yrs) | **Indirect:** President, VP, Rajya Sabha
- **FPTP** → LS & Vidhan Sabha; **PR-STV** → RS, President, VP, Vidhan Parishad; FPTP: most votes wins even <50%; PR: seats ∝ votes
- **STV:** quota = valid votes ÷ seats; lowest eliminated → transfer to 2nd preference
- **6 bicameral states:** AP, Bihar, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Telangana, UP
- **RPA 1950** = seats, delimitation, rolls, 18+ | **RPA 1951** = nomination, campaigns, voting, disputes, corrupt practices
- **Delimitation: Article 82; 4 commissions — 1952, 1963, 1973, 2002**
- **ECI: 25 Jan 1950** (National Voters' Day); Articles **324–329**; "superintendence, direction & control"
- **Anti-Defection: 1985, 52nd Amendment** — leaving party / defying whip → disqualification (Speaker/Chairman decides)
- **Coalitions:** 1967 alliance era; **1977 Janata = first national coalition**; NDA (BJP) & UPA → INDIA alliance (2023)
- **Challenges → remedies:** misinformation, fake news, intimidation → RPA, MCC, VVPAT, awareness campaigns

12 🧠 Memory Tricks

🧠 **Bicameral 6 "ABKMTU":** Aaj Bharat Ki Maha-Teleangana-UP — Andhra, Bihar, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Telangana, UP

🧠 **RPA acts:** "50 = Foundation (rolls), 51 = Fight (conduct & disputes)"

🧠 **FPTP vs PR — "Race vs Pie":** race mein sabse aage jeeta; pie mein jitna vote, utna hissa

🧠 **Corrupt practices "BCG":** Bribery, Communal appeal, Government-personnel misuse

🧠 **Delimitation years:** 52-63-73-2002 (gap badhao: +11, +10, phir 29 saal jump)

🧠 **ECI apps "SEVS SCE" (Sewa-SC!):** Suvidha, ENCORE, Voter Helpline, Saksham, cVIGIL, Sugam, ETPBS

🧠 **National party criteria "6-4-4 / 2-3 / 4-states":** 6% in 4 states + 4 LS seats; OR 2% LS seats from 3 states; OR state party in 4 states

🧠 **Elections importance "ARLE":** Aa Rahe hai Elections! — Accountability, Representation, Legitimacy, Equality

13 ⚡ Last 5-Minute Revision — read before entering the exam hall

🗓️ DATES & NUMBERS
25 January 1950 — ECI established → National Voters' Day
RPA **1950** & **1951**; Presidential & VP Act **1952**
Delimitation: **1952, 1963, 1973, 2002** • Anti-Defection: **1985** (52nd Amdt)
1967 alliance era; **1977** Janata coalition • elections every 5 yrs; voting age **18+**
Voting from home: **85+ & PwDs (40% benchmark)** — 2024 first nationwide

⚖️ KEY DIFFERENCES
Direct (LS, VS, local) vs Indirect (President, VP, RS)
FPTP (most votes, <50% possible) vs Majority (>50% / 2 rounds) vs PR (seats ∝ votes)
National vs State party (recognition criteria) • Recognised vs RUPP
RPA 1950 (rolls) vs RPA 1951 (conduct + disputes)

🧠 ECI IN ONE BREATH
Autonomous, permanent, constitutional; Articles 324–329; "superintendence, direction & control" of ALL elections
Rolls (+SIR) + schedule (weather, agriculture, exams, festivals) + party registration/symbols (quasi-judicial) + fairness (85+, PwDs, Braille EVMs)

📱 APPS (NAME → WORK)
Suvidha — candidates' permissions • **Voter Helpline** — registration • **ENCORE** — forms, e-rolls
Saksham — PwD services • **cVIGIL** — MCC violations (flying squads) • **Sugam** — vehicles • **ETPBS** — service voters
IEVP: MoUs with 28 EMBs + IFES, IDEA, UN

⚡ RAPID-FIRE
Psephology = scientific study of elections (psēphos = pebble) • Quota = valid votes ÷ seats
Vidhan Parishad: MLAs + local bodies + graduates & teachers elect; Governor nominates some
Corrupt practices: bribery, communal appeals, govt-personnel help • Defection = leaving your ticket's party
First national coalition: Janata govt (1977, post-Emergency) • No voter left behind — station even for one voter

14 📝 How to Use These Points in an Answer

- **Formula:** Introduction (1–2 lines — define the system/institution) → Body (3–5 numbered points with keywords + the textbook example) → Conclusion (1 line evaluation). Underline acts, articles & dates.
- **Q: "Explain the First-Past-The-Post system with an example." (3–5m):** Intro = FPTP (plurality) chosen by the framers for LS & Vidhan Sabha. Body = ① one vote per candidate in constituency ② MOST votes wins — even <50% of votes polled ③ example: Haritbhumi — A (40%) beats B (35%) & C (25%), forms government ④ contrast: majority system (needs >50%, two rounds) & PR (seats proportional). Conclusion = FPTP is simple with clear winners, though a winner may lack majority support.
- **Q: "Describe the functions of the Election Commission of India." (5m):** Intro = ECI (25 Jan 1950; Articles 324–329) autonomous permanent constitutional body with superintendence, direction & control. Body = ① prepares & revises rolls (enumerators, SIR, claims & objections) ② decides schedule (weather, agricultural cycle, exams, festivals) ③ registers parties, allots symbols, quasi-judicial disputes, inner-party democracy ④ free, fair & inclusive — MCC, VVPAT, PwD/85+/transgender/PVTG inclusion, digital apps ⑤ state machinery: CEO → DEOs, ROs, EROs. Conclusion = ECI upholds the world's largest democratic exercise.
- **Q (case study): "From Ishani's first vote — (a) ECI initiatives? (b) which other document? (c) MCC violations?" (5m):** ① online registration through ECI portal ② wheelchair + volunteers for her brother (PwD inclusion — Saksham) ③ voting from home for the 89-year-old grandmother (85+ & 40% benchmark PwDs) ④ other officially valid documents (passport, driving licence…) accepted without Voter ID ⑤ VVPAT slip verified her vote; violations = wall writings, posters, pamphlets near polling day; police on duty vote as service voters via ETPBS. Conclusion = "no voter is left behind."